

Although the term “best friend” only became widely used in the 20th century, the idea has existed since ancient times. The famous philosopher Aristotle described three kinds of friendship: those based on pleasure, on usefulness, and on virtue. Friendships of virtue were considered the highest form. These relationships are not just enjoyable or practical — they are stronger and last longer because each person tries to help the other become a better person.

Best friendships were especially important for women in the past, says Jaimie Arona Krems, an associate professor of psychology and director of the UCLA Center for Friendship Research. Historically, when women married, they often left their own homes and communities to live with their husbands’ families. Without their own relatives nearby, friends — especially best friends — became essential sources of support. Today, many young adults move away from their hometowns for school or work, so friends often take on roles similar to family.

In studies, people describe friends with words like trustworthy, honest, supportive, loyal, reliable, kind, pleasant, available, positive, open, understanding, and fun. Best friends share all of these qualities, but more deeply. Krems explains: “There’s more trust, more openness, more understanding, more emotional closeness, a stronger feeling of shared reality.” You can also have more than one best friend, depending on the situation — such as a best friend from childhood, from work, or from the gym.

Whether a spouse should be considered a best friend is often debated. In Krems’s research, many people do not list their romantic partner or family member as their best friend, even though they say they want their partner to be one.

Calling someone a “best friend” also means admitting that other friends are less close. This may sound cold, but researchers say people naturally rank their relationships. One theory, suggested by British evolutionary psychologist Robin Dunbar, says humans can only maintain about 150 social connections — known as Dunbar’s number. These people are placed into different layers, from the closest friends in the inner circle to people you might only recognize on the street. Because our time and emotional energy are limited, we can’t stay close to everyone we know. So, we are more likely to invest in the friends we have already spent a lot of time with — usually the three to five people in our closest circle.

This ranking system can sometimes become uncomfortable or obvious in public. For example, at weddings, one person is chosen as the best man or maid of honor. This can surprise others because people often hide their friendship rankings, Krems explains, to “make several people believe they are our best friend.”

Question 21. According to the philosopher Aristotle, what is the highest form of friendship?

- A) A bond built mainly for pleasure
 - B) A useful connection for daily needs
 - C) A social link based on shared interests
 - D) A bond where both help each other grow**
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Question 22. Why were close friendships especially important for women in the past?

- A) They were expected to avoid social events.
 - B) They rarely had time to make new friends.
 - C) They often lived far from their original families.**
 - D) They mainly relied on their husbands' relatives.
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Question 23. What is one key difference between best friends and regular friends?

- A) Best friends always agree on everything.
 - B) Best friends show deeper trust and openness.**
 - C) Best friends know what you really need.
 - D) Best friends rarely have conflicts or distance.
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Question 24. According to the passage, why do people tend to invest more in a few close friends?

- A) Because it is considered rude to have many friends.
 - B) Because friendships formed later in life are less stable.
 - C) Because society expects people to maintain lifelong friendships.
 - D) Because people have limited time and emotional energy.**
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Question 25. According to Krems, why do people often hide their friendship rankings?

- A) To spend more time building new friendships
- B) To avoid debates about spouses as best friends
- C) To make people believe they are the best friend**
- D) To increase their total number of social connections

答案 : D, C, B, D, C